

**ECON 230 – Introduction to Behavioural Economics
Winter 2027**

Instructor Information	
Instructor	Muhebullah Karimzada
Contact Information	✉ karimzada@unbc.ca ☎ Phone: TBA
Office Location & Hours	10-4522 ⌚ Tue: 2:30 pm – 4:00 pm Thu: 2:30 pm – 4:00 pm or by appointment
Teaching Assistant	✉ TBA

Course Information	
Lectures	Tuesday and Thursday from 1:00 pm to 2:30 pm in Room TBA
Course Format	In-Person
Course Description	This course examines why individuals, firms, and institutions sometimes make harmful or irrational choices. Using theoretical and empirical perspectives from economics and psychology, students explore how biases, habits, and social influences shape behaviour in areas such as financial fraud, addiction, tax evasion, workplace misconduct, and deceptive business practices. The course also analyses the conditions under which markets amplify or mitigate these behaviours and evaluates the effectiveness of policy interventions designed to address them. Emphasis is placed on evidence-based analysis and a systematic assessment of the limits of standard rational-choice models.
Required Text	TBA
Additional Resources	Lecture slides, practice problem sets, and supplementary readings are posted on Moodle.

Evaluation & Assessments

Learning in this course results primarily from lectures, in-class discussions, home readings, and practice problem sets. Students learning and progress in this course will be evaluated on individual basis. Grades for this course will be calculated as follows:

Assessment	Weight	Due Date
In-class quizzes	15%	TBA
In-class discussions	15%	
Midterm exam	30%	
Final Exam	40%	
Total	100%	

Course schedule by week

Week	Date	Topic	Evaluation Due Dates
1	Jan 7th	Introduction: What is Behavioural Economics? <i>We start by asking a simple question: if people are rational, why do they make so many bad decisions? This week sets up the core tension of the course and introduces the scholars who changed how we think about it.</i>	
2	Jan 12th & 14th	Bounded Rationality and Cognitive Limitations <i>People do not optimize. They simplify, rely on rules of thumb, and stop when a solution feels good enough. We look at where those shortcuts come from and how System 1 and System 2 thinking shape everyday choices.</i>	
3	Jan 19th & 21st	Heuristics and Cognitive Biases <i>Anchoring, availability, representativeness, overconfidence: these are the mental shortcuts people rely on when making decisions under uncertainty. We go through each one and look at the surprisingly predictable mistakes they produce.</i>	
4	Jan 26th & 28th	Prospect Theory and Loss Aversion <i>Kahneman and Tversky showed that people do not evaluate outcomes in terms of final wealth but in terms of gains and losses relative to a reference point, and that losses hurt roughly twice as much as equivalent gains feel good. This lecture builds the model and traces its implications.</i>	

5	Feb 2nd & 4th	Time Inconsistency and Present Bias <i>Most of us plan to start saving, exercise, or quit smoking soon, but somehow soon never comes. We work through the economics of why present rewards are weighted so heavily, and what it takes to actually commit to a future plan.</i>	
6	Feb 9th & 11th	Social Preferences, Fairness, and Reciprocity <i>Standard theory says people care about their own payoffs. Experiments say otherwise. We play a series of games in class to see how much fairness, trust, and reciprocity actually drive decisions, and what that means for wages, organizations, and public policy.</i>	
	Feb 15th – Feb 19th	UNBC Mid-Semester Break	
7	Feb 23rd & 25th	Savings, Self-Control, and Retirement Behaviour <i>Canadians know they should save more. Most do not. This lecture looks at the psychological reasons behind that gap, from mental accounting to the sunk-cost fallacy, and reviews the policy tools that have actually moved the needle.</i>	
8	Mar 2nd & 4th	Behavioural Game Theory <i>Game theory assumes players reason through their opponents' thinking step by step. Real players do not get very far. We look at how people actually play strategic situations and what that reveals about reasoning, cooperation, and trust.</i>	
9	Mar 9th & 11th	Behavioural Finance and Market Anomalies <i>In 2000, Cisco's stock price implied it would eventually become larger than the entire US economy. People bought it anyway. This lecture asks how smart investors end up creating irrational markets, and why arbitrage does not always correct the problem.</i>	
10	Mar 16th & 18th	Nudge Theory and Choice Architecture <i>Small changes to how choices are presented can shift behaviour dramatically without restricting anyone's freedom. We look at how default rules, framing, and social norms are used by governments and firms, and where the limits of nudging lie.</i>	
11	Mar 23rd & 25th	Policy Design and Behavioural Interventions <i>When should a government inform, incentivize, nudge, or simply mandate? We pull together the tools from across the course and evaluate what the evidence says about each approach in health, finance, and tax policy.</i>	
12-13	Mar 30th - Apr 8th	Applications - Health, Labour, and Consumer Markets <i>We bring the course into contact with real sectors: why people stay in bad jobs, why misleading credit offers work, and why health interventions so often fail to change behaviour. The goal is to connect the theory to decisions you will actually encounter.</i>	

14	Apr 13th	Final Exam Review <i>We go through the key models, findings, and policy debates from the semester, with emphasis on integrating ideas across topics in preparation for the final exam.</i>	
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Please Note:

1. For some chapters selected portions will be covered as a part of the course material.
2. If a student misses a lecture for any reason, it is student's responsibility to obtain class lecture notes and other relevant material.
3. There will be five in-class quizzes, with dates listed in the table above. Each quiz will be held during the last 30 minutes of the lecture. Only your top four scores will be counted, giving you one free pass. A missed quiz will automatically be considered your free pass.
4. Quizzes, midterm, and the final exam are strictly individual assessments and will be closed book.
5. Quizzes, midterm, and the final exam will feature a mix of question types, including short answer, analytical problems, numerical calculations, mathematical derivations, true/false, multiple choice, and fill-in-the-blank.
6. Your grades on quizzes and midterm will be posted on Moodle. Please immediately report to the instructor any discrepancy between the posted and actual grades.
7. Only the Registrar's Office can issue final grades. Hence, marks for the final exam will not be posted on Moodle.
8. You are encouraged to contact course instructor or course TA for any questions on the course material and outlines, evaluation scheme, and the final exam.

Artificial Intelligence (AI)

Use of generative AI is NOT allowed in this course, unless specifically authorized by the instructor. Please consult with the instructor if any clarification is needed. General guidance on the acceptability of using generative AI at UNBC can be found [here](#).

Plagiarism

Plagiarism is a misrepresentation of information that can result in a misattribution of credit, up to and including representing someone else's work as your own. When you incorporate the words, ideas, graphics, or other products from someone else's work into your projects, you must give credit by providing a citation and reference to the source work.

It is your responsibility to:

1. Familiarize yourself with and understand the information on [plagiarism](#) provided by the Academic Success Centre,
2. And the UNBC policy on Student Conduct, plagiarism and other academic offenses, as described in the UNBC Undergraduate calendar.

Grading System - Undergraduate Assessments

Grade Point	Letter Grade	Percentage	Definition/Standing
4.33	A+	90 -100%	Excellent
4.00	A	85-89.9%	
3.67	A-	80-84.9%	
3.33	B+	77-79.9%	Good
3.00	B	73-76.9%	
2.67	B-	70-72.9%	
2.33	C+	67-69.9%	Satisfactory
2.00	C	63-66.9%	
1.67	C-	60-62.9%	Marginal
1.33	D+	57-59.9%	
1.00	D	53-56.9%	
0.67	D-	50-62.9%	
0.00	F	0-49.9%	Failure

Student Services

University students often encounter setbacks from time to time that can impact academic performance. If you experience difficulties and need assistance, it's important to reach out. The following resources are available **free** to all students at UNBC and can help address mental, emotional, or physical health concerns:

General IT & Moodle Support

IT Services can assist you with accessing your UNBC account or Moodle, please email support@unbc.ca or visit their [Support for Students](#) page. If you have specific questions or errors while uploading assignments, using video, Kaltura etc. contact the Centre for Teaching Learning & Technology at ctlit@unbc.ca.

Academic Advising

For questions regarding course load, understanding your degree requirements or your GPA please reach out to Academic Advising located in the Enrollment Services Room 7-702.

Webpage: [Student Advising](#)

Phone: 250-960-6306

Email: advising@unbc.ca

The Academic Success Centre (ASC)

The Academic Success Centre provides students with free access to academic support services: Tutoring (by appointment, asynchronous online, or drop-in), personalized study skills assessments and peer-led course supports. ASC services are available in person (room 5-139) at the Prince George Campus and online

Webpage: [Academic Success Centre](#)

Phone: 250-960-6367 | Toll Free 1-888-440-3440

Email: asc@unbc.ca

Access Resource Centre (ARC)

The Access Resource Centre (ARC) provides services to students with documented health conditions and/or disabilities. ARC staff are available to meet with you to determine which academic accommodation can be put in place to support you in achieving their academic goals, provide referrals, and help advocate for you.

Webpage: [Access Resource Centre](#)

Phone: 250-960-5682 | Toll Free 1-888-960-5682

Email: arc@unbc.ca

UNBC Counselling Services

Offers counseling for all students as well as access to First Nations Counseling Services

Offers health and general services that support academic success and personal wellbeing of students

Webpage: [UNBC Counselling Services](#)

Phone: 250-960-6369

Email: wellness@unbc.ca

Crisis Centre for Northern BC (24/7)

If you are feeling overwhelmed, depressed, confused, suicidal, or just needing someone to listen to, the crisis line provides emotional support, suicide intervention and referral information. If you are unable to meet course expectations due to mental health reasons, please discuss your situation with your instructor, counsellor or/and an academic advisor.

Webpage: <https://crisis-centre.ca/>

Phone: Northern BC: [1-888-562-1214](tel:1-888-562-1214) | Youth Support: [1-888-564-8336](tel:1-888-564-8336) | Anywhere in BC: [1-800-784-2433](tel:1-800-784-2433)

UNBC SAFE app

UNBC SAFE features emergency contacts, services, information and safety tips. Emergency messaging can be sent to you via Push notifications when enabled. Download the App [here](#).

UNBC Athletics

Please note that students involved in University Athletics will be required to notify the instructor at least two weeks in advance of any official athletics commitments (e.g., games, travel) that conflict with due dates.

Food Security

We understand the cost of living is higher than ever, and it's hard to learn when you're hungry. The [NUGSS Food Bank](#) (located in the NUGSS office in Building 6) is open to all students.